

UNIVERSITY OF ESSEX

Undergraduate Examination 2013

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**CURRENT DISPUTES IN SOCIOLOGY: SOCIOLOGICAL ANALYSIS III**

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Time allowed: **THREE** hours

Candidates are permitted to bring into the examination room paper dictionaries (with the title in English).

Candidates must answer **THREE** questions in total: **ONE** from **SECTION A**, **ONE** from **SECTION B**, and **ONE** from either **SECTION A** or **SECTION B**.

The paper consists of **eighteen** questions in total: ten in Section A and eight in Section B.

All questions are of equal weight.

**Please do not leave your seat unless you are given permission by an invigilator.**  
**Do not communicate in any way with any other candidate in the examination room.**  
**Do not open the question paper until told to do so.**  
**All answers must be written in the answer book(s) provided.**  
**All rough work must be written in the answer book(s) provided. A line should be drawn through any rough work to indicate to the examiner that it is not part of the work to be marked.**  
**At the end of the examination, remain seated until your answer book(s) have been collected and you have been told you may leave.**

**SECTION A**

**Candidates must answer THREE questions in total: one from Section A, one from Section B, and one from either Section A or Section B.**

1. Does sociology study facts?
2. Is it more important for sociology to explain the world or understand the world?
3. Is reality a social construction? You should refer to the work of phenomenologists in your answer.
4. Why do critical realists talk of the “real”, the “actual” and the “empirical”? What are the implications for sociological analysis?
5. How successful was Popper in countering the “problem of induction”? How are his arguments relevant for sociology?
6. Is scientific knowledge a product of social factors or of the ‘natural’ phenomena that scientists observe?
7. Should sociologists talk of “feminism” or “feminisms”?
8. How have feminist epistemologists tried to reformulate the notion of “objectivity”? Why is this important?
9. Outline and assess Du Bois’ notion of “double consciousness”.
10. Did the West construct the “Rest”?

**END OF SECTION A**

**SECTION B**

**Candidates must answer THREE questions in total: one from Section A, one from Section B, and one from either Section A or Section B.**

11. In modern democracies, power is not negative, but productive. Critically discuss this statement with reference to work by Foucault.
12. “[I]t is quite possible that the major mechanisms of power have been accompanied by ideological productions...but basically I do not believe that what has taken place can be said to be ideological. It is both much more and much less than ideology” (Foucault). Discuss the significance of this statement for understanding the operation of power in modern liberal democracies.
13. What does Bourdieu mean by “habitus”? How successful is this concept in accounting for social inequality?
14. Why does Barthes think that “Mythology” is an important tool for analysing contemporary society?
15. Using at least two authors, critically assess how sociologists have conceptualised modernity.
16. “All that is solid melts into air”. How well does this statement characterise postmodernity?
17. How effectively have sociologists risen to the challenge of the global ecological crisis?
18. Critically assess the dialogical approach to sociological analysis.

**END OF SECTION B**

**END OF PAPER SC301-6-FY**